Phoenix.Inc

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SYNOPSIS

Haunted by regrets and bad memories, the old man Dick visits a healthcare company called Phoenix.Inc. Their treatments offer a new way of changing and reliving past situations. Will Dick be able to change his past successfully?

SETTING

2040s in a subtly futuristic world.

CHARACTERS

OLD DICK - - - 51, he/him, wears a white shirt and black trousers for the whole play

YOUNG DICK - - - 21, he/him, wears colored t-shirts and jeans

TEEN DICK - - - 16, he/him, wears high school uniform

DOCTOR DAVIS- - - 45, he/him, the main doctor who performs the procedure at Phoenix.Inc.

COMPUTER - - - a robotic voice, the Artificial Intelligence that learns and mimics human behavior

LAURA --- 20, she/her, YOUNG DICK’s love interest

BEN --- 21, he/him, YOUNG DICK’s good friend

RECEPTIONIST - - - 50-70, she/her, an old lady with a calming voice

LADY MARIONETTE - - - 20-30, female voice for the puppet, the star of the advertisement

SKELETON MARIONETTE - - -40-50, male voice for the puppet, the star of the advertisement

Lighting plays an important role in this play, so it is important to get the colors correct. ‘Present’ day scenes with OLD DICK should be gray and muted. Memory scenes with YOUNG DICK should be more yellow and vibrant.

Campus by Kale is an original song by the playwright. There is also a piano rendition. (cannot be found anywhere yet, Dec 9, 2024) If cannot be found, it can be substituted by any appropriate song.

The memory scene from pages 12-13-14 can be demonstrated as creatively as the director desires. One suggestion would be using marionettes or shadow puppets to prevent harsh set changes in a small amount of time.

ACT I
SCENE 1

The lights are dim. Curtains are down.
A beat to a song starts playing. Cheerful singing starts in the background.

LADY MARIONETTE
One! Two! Three!

LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE
Here we go again!

Curtains open. Two life-size string puppets stand in the middle of the stage. LADY MARIONETTE is a beautiful lady puppet. SKELETON MARIONETTE is just a skeleton.

SKELETON MARIONETTE
When nights are long,
And you see shadows in the halls,

LADY MARIONETTE
When everything's wrong,
And you are staring at white walls,

LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE
What do you do?

LADY MARIONETTE
When friends are gone
and you've lost everything you could lose,

SKELETON MARIONETTE
You hold on tight
to mistakes you can't undo,

LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE
Then, what do you do?

LADY MARIONETTE
When there's a clash between…

SKELETON MARIONETTE
Something you wish to change,

LADY MARIONETTE
Your mind!

SKELETON MARIONETTE

And something you can’t change,

LADY MARIONETTE

Time! Time!

LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE

What do you do?

Both MARIONETTEs slide to the side. DOCTOR DAVIS enters the stage.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Hi! I am Doctor Davis from Phoenix.Inc. I am here to tell you about our most innovative treatment yet. Our latest technological advancements have allowed us to essentially… rewrite time. Yes! You heard that right. Rewriting your past. Memories you wish you never had. Memories you wish to change. Memories you wish to experience. Infused with the greatest artificial intelligence, our newest treatment can write you the perfect life you’ve always dreamed of. Still has doubts? Visit Phoenix.Inc. and announce… you are here to change your mind!

DOCTOR DAVIS takes a few steps backward and exits the stage. LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE come back to the middle.

LADY MARIONETTE

Here to change your mind!

SKELETON MARIONETTE

Here to change your mind!

LADY MARIONETTE

Changed your mind?

SKELETON MARIONETTE

Change your mind.

LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE

And change your life!

YOUNG DICK screams in the background.

YOUNG DICK

I AM GOING TO CHANGE MY LIFE!!!

SCENE 2

In a hospital lobby. Reception music plays in the background.
Black and white lighting.
Extras as patients (could be LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE) are seated. OLD DICK is talking to the RECEPTIONIST, signing some papers.

RECEPTIONIST
So, you are here to change your mind.

OLD DICK
That's what you guys advertised. Yeah.

RECEPTIONIST
(laughs endearingly) You look nervous. Don't be… I know it seems unnatural. Strange. But, who's to tell you how to live your life? Plus, our technology is extremely safe and we are very cautious with our premium patients.
beat.
You have nothing to worry about. Take a seat. Doctor Davis will come get you in a second.

OLD DICK
Sounds good.

OLD DICK walks toward the chairs in the lobby. He picks up a pamphlet on a desk before sitting down. He flips through the pages. DOCTOR DAVIS enters the stage from the back.

DOCTOR DAVIS
RICHARD NELSON?

OLD DICK
That's me. Yes. Hi! You can just call me Dick.

DOCTOR DAVIS
Dick. Very nice to meet you. My name is Doctor Davis. I am going to take very good care of you today. How are we feeling?

OLD DICK
Pretty good. Nervous.

RECEPTIONIST and extras exist the stage, taking the chairs and props. DOCTOR DAVIS and OLD DICK continue talking during this time.

DOCTOR DAVIS

It's completely normal to feel nervous before the treatment. I am here to take good care of you. Let's go to my room. I will first explain the procedure. You can ask me any burning questions afterward. Then, we can procceed. How does that sound?

OLD DICK

Sounds good!

Extras bring out props for the doctor's room. There is an examination table, a desk, some chairs, and a computer. Extras exist the stage. DOCTOR DAVIS and OLD DICK are now in the doctor's room.

DOCTOR DAVIS

So, here's what you are going to do for me. You are going to be lying down on this examination table and relax. That's it.

OLD DICK

Okay.

DOCTOR DAVIS

And, here is what I am going to do. I am going to place a bunch of these circle magnets all over your head. They are going to be interacting with the critical parts of your brain that control memory. Then, I am going to upload your memory to the computer and we can navigate through each instance. Do you have a specific period that you want to go back to?

OLD DICK

Yeah. Laura. I want to experience the first time I met her again.

beat.

I also want to fix the last fight we had before she packed her things and left.

DOCTOR DAVIS

(smiles) That's very sweet of you. You said the first time you met her. Do you remember the date? Or maybe the time range?

OLD DICK

Yes. December 19, 2014. It was at this college party.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Okay. *(scrolls through the computer)* Let me just search for that.

beat.

Here it is. Let me just select that evening.

DOCTOR DAVIS presses some keys on the keyboard.

DOCTOR DAVIS

While our machine is installing and learning the behaviors of people in your memory, I will explain this experience to you. I am going to put you to sleep. We will not

record or store any of your memories, but we will be monitoring them just for your safety.

beat.

Also, while you are ‘asleep’, you will be in an extremely realistic version of the memory you chose. It is important to note that you are only re-experiencing the memory for now, not changing it yet. At any point you decide you want to change the memory, you will say “COMPUTER! Enter!” This will allow our COMPUTER AI to detect that you want to modify the following memory. If you do it correctly, you will hear this sound.

DOCTOR DAVIS presses a button on the computer screen.

COMPUTER

Memory sliced! Patient entered successfully!

DOCTOR DAVIS

Then, you can talk and change your actions. Our cutting-edge technology of generative AI will utilize what it learned of the person you are interacting with and will respond accordingly to your change. When you make a change, you will hear this sound.

DOCTOR DAVIS presses another button on the computer screen.

COMPUTER

Memory updated! Past altered successfully!

DOCTOR DAVIS

And, at any point, you are free to interact with our AI just by saying COMPUTER and a commend. It can recognize most commends like ‘pause’, ‘fast-forward’, ‘skip a day’, and so on. Got it?

OLD DICK

Yeah. *(stares blankly into the walls of the doctor’s office)* Just one question. How real will it be?

DOCTOR DAVIS

(leans in with a grin) Oh, it will be pretty real. Trust me. As we promised.

There is a ding! Computer screen changes color. Learning is complete. COMPUTER is ready.

DOCTOR DAVIS

There we go. Are you excited for a new life?

OLD DICK

Yeah.

DOCTOR DAVIS

One more thing. You will only have half an hour for your treatment. So, I recommend you make use of our fast-forward feature.

DOCTOR DAVIS navigates through the computer screen.

So, Dick, are you ready?

OLD DICK

(nervous) Yes. I think I am ready.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Perfect. December 19, 2014, here we come!

Lights dim to black.

SCENE 3

BEN

(screaming) SENIOR PARTY, HERE WE COME!

Lights come on. It is the evening of December 19, 2014.
A college party. Rooftop.
Sunset. Blues, purples, and pinks fly in the sky, sinking into the clouds.
College kids (aged 19-23) stand in the background, mingling and chatting. One is a beautiful young woman in a flowy red dress. BEN and YOUNG DICK stand on the opposite side with drinks in hand.

YOUNG DICK

You seem cheerful now.

BEN

Yeah. What do you want me to do? Be depressed at the BEST PARTY OF OUR LIVES?

YOUNG DICK

I am happy for you.

BEN

I am happy for… all the hot girls at this party! What, man? Are you finally gonna take your little buddy out of the slammer?

YOUNG DICK

Huh?

BEN

(leans into YOUNG DICK) And into a hottie's *(whispers)* **pussy**?

YOUNG DICK pushes BEN.

YOUNG DICK

You are… one of a kind.
Pause.

BEN

So you like her?

YOUNG DICK

Huh?

BEN

I see you… eyeing that girl. Every… single… second… allllll… evening.

YOUNG DICK

(shrugs) I don't know her.

BEN

You want to know her?

YOUNG DICK smiles. BEN stares into YOUNG DICK's eyes. YOUNG DICK looks to the side.

BEN

(leans into YOUNG DICK with a smirk) You like her?

YOUNG DICK shrugs his shoulders.

YOU DO LIKE HER!

YOUNG DICK hastily covers BEN's mouth with his hand.

YOUNG DICK

Shut! The…
(whispers) fuck. up.

BEN

Make me.

YOUNG DICK stares into BEN's eyes.

YOUNG DICK

Okay. I am going to go talk to her.

BEN

Okay.

YOUNG DICK

Yeah! I am going to get her number.

BEN

Yeah! That's what I'm talking about!

YOUNG DICK

I am going to make her my girlfriend! I am going to marry her! Have ten kids together!

BEN

Oh wow, okay, buddy. Slowww down.

YOUNG DICK

(chucks his drink) I AM GOING TO CHANGE MY LIFE!!!

YOUNG DICK walks up to the girl in a red dress. She is standing alone with a glass of red wine, staring into the sunset like she had conjured lives outside of this world. YOUNG DICK stands next to her. She doesn't notice him.

YOUNG DICK

(clears his throat) Uhmm hmm. Hey.

The girl gasps. She jumps like she got yanked back to reality. She drops her wine glass. She spills wine on her dress.

YOUNG DICK

Oh. My. God! I am sooo sorry. Are you okay?

LAURA

OH GOD. This is my roommate's dress.

LAURA pads down wet spots on her dress, still turning away from YOUNG DICK.

It's okay. Don't worry about it. What do you need?

LAURA turns around. They meet eyes for the first time… again.
Tears begin to form in YOUNG DICK's eyes.

YOUNG DICK

Computer! Pause.

COMPUTER

Memory paused!

Everyone is frozen in time. YOUNG DICK runs his hand down LAURA's cheeks.

YOUNG DICK

(whispers) I missed you.

Pause.

YOUNG DICK wipes his tears with his t-shirt and fixes his posture.

YOUNG DICK

Computer! Resume.

COMPUTER

Memory unpaused!

Everyone is moving again. LAURA smiles.

LAURA

Stranger, who might you be?

YOUNG DICK

(nervously fixes his shirt) Dick! My name is Dick!

LAURA chuckles subtly. YOUNG DICK notices.

Actually, you can call me Richard. What's yours?

LAURA

I am Laura.

beat.

Are you looking for someone?

YOUNG DICK

Yeah, I was looking for someone who can make this party more tolerable… Then, I saw you.

LAURA

Oh.

YOUNG DICK

Yeah…

LAURA glances up and down at YOUNG DICK and smiles.

LAURA

(holding her dress) So, Dick, what are you going to do about my dress?

YOUNG DICK

Oh shit. I am sorry. Hmm. I might have an extra dress at my dorm. If you want to come visit.

LAURA

Oh, do you now?

YOUNG DICK

Well, you might have to settle for a red t-shirt and jeans, but they would fit you great!

beat.

I mean you would fit great in anything… Even nothing.

LAURA gives YOUNG DICK a look.

LAURA

Oh, I see…

YOUNG DICK

Plus, I could show you my prized treasure.

LAURA

If that is an innuendo for dick, Dick, I am not interested. I don't have time for quick love cons.

YOUNG DICK

Perfect. Because I am not looking for an one-night stand either. I am looking for love.

LAURA

Oh, really?

YOUNG DICK

Really.

LAURA gives YOUNG DICK a look again.

(nods repeatedly) Really. Really. I will show you the universe… If you come with me.

LAURA

And, how are you gonna do that?

YOUNG DICK

(smirks) I have a big long thing. *(makes a gesture of an 8 to 9 inches thing with two hands)* That can. um. show you the stars.

LAURA replies, but her voice is muffled as COMPUTER interrupts.

COMPUTER

30 minutes left!

YOUNG DICK is shocked by how fast time flew by. He realizes he needs to hurry.

YOUNG DICK

Computer! Fast forward.

COMPUTER

Memory speeding up!

The lights soften. A faint glow remains.
Everyone and everything moves fast as if in a two or three times sped-up video.
YOUNG DICK and LAURA enter his dorm room, conversating but cannot be heard by the audience. There is an object covered with cloth standing near the window. YOUNG DICK pulls away the cloth. A telescope appears. YOUNG DICK grabs LAURA's hand and places it on the telescope. LAURA looks into the telescope.

⋆｡°☆ Stars light up the whole stage. ⋆｡°☆

YOUNG DICK brings out a vinyl and places it on the record player. He counts the lines on the vinyl and carefully places the needle. He mouths, "This is my favorite song" to LAURA.
The original version of "Campus" by Kale starts playing in the background.

LAURA smiles. They talk. She leans in.
They kiss.
⋆｡°☆ Stars are now flying and moving across the stage. ⋆｡°☆

They are walking. Getting coffee. Then, dinner. Then, movies.
They are back in the room. YOUNG DICK texts his roommate. They disappear under the bed sheets.

They reappear now in graduation gowns. YOUNG DICK, LAURA, and BEN take photos together. They raise a toast. YOUNG DICK and LAURA move to the same city after graduation. They kept the telescope.

LAURA is a nurse and YOUNG DICK is an accountant. They go to work. They come back from work. They adopted a baby cat. One dinner. Two dinners. YOUNG DICK's phone rings but he hangs up without picking up. It is just the two of them and everyone else just seems to cease to exist.

Three dinners. Four dinners. Now, it is Thanksgiving dinner with LAURA's parents. Now, it is Christmas dinner. They kiss after dinner. LAURA turns to get her present for YOUNG DICK. YOUNG DICK gets down on one knee. LAURA nods a million times, covering her face with her hands.

They are in a suit and a white gown. YOUNG DICK lifts LAURA and spins her around. They kiss.
They are back home.
Now, they are laughing.
Now, they are looking through the telescope.
Now, LAURA is at her dad's funeral, staring at the coffin.
Now, YOUNG DICK is walking her home.
Now, YOUNG DICK is crying, holding his phone and LAURA is comforting him.
Now, they are flipping through the senior yearbook, reminiscing on college days.
Now, YOUNG DICK is cuddling his now-adult cat.
Now, they are at the graveyard with sunflowers.

Now, they are back home.
Now, they are watching tv.
Now, LAURA is exhausted and YOUNG DICK gives her a hug.
Now, YOUNG DICK is sad again, thinking about changing his past.
LAURA pads his back gently. YOUNG DICK walks away.
Now, they are back in the living room.
Now, they are looking through the telescope.
Now, they are laughing.
Now, they are smiling.
Now, they are sad again.

YOUNG DICK

Computer!

Now, they are fighting.
★。°☆ Stars stop flying across the stage.

YOUNG DICK

STOP!!!

beat.

LAURA

DON'T YOU EVER TELL ME TO STOP! NOT WHEN YOU ARE THE ONE WHO STARTED THIS… WHOLE THING.

COMPUTER

Memory is now normal speed!

YOUNG DICK

I WASN'T TELLING YOU TO STOP TALKING, LAURA. I JUST NEED YOU TO STOP… yelling.

LAURA

LAURA?! ALSO, I AM NOT YELLING. I JUST NEED MY VOICE TO BE HEARD. EVERY. DAY. AND YOU JUST WON'T SEE ME… or you just choose not to see me.

YOUNG DICK

I see you.

LAURA

(begins crying) Then why do you keep doing this?

YOUNG DICK

Doing what?!

LAURA

Ignoring me.

YOUNG DICK
Because you won't stop it. Goddd, now I know how he felt.

LAURA
I care about you. Is that too much for a wife to do for her husband?

YOUNG DICK
But, I don't want to keep hearing it EVERY. SINGLE. DAY.

LAURA
(stutters) I don't think I can stop worrying.

YOUNG DICK
WHAT? You think I am going to kill myself, too?! Is that why?

LAURA
(sobs) That's not what I am saying. It's just… just…

beat.

You have been through a lot… Dick. And, I kept seeing dead patients at my work and kept wondering what I would do if it were you that I saw on that hospital bed. What would I do when I am at work and I get a phone call? I can't leave work without checking in excessively with you first. At work, I check your location every single minute. This is not normal. But, at least I am trying to make it work. At least, I am going to work.

beat.

I chose to be here with you. But, you are always just pushing me away… I can't do this.

YOUNG DICK
You can't do this? I can't do this either. Maybe we should \ …

DICK *(plays over the speaker)*
Computer! Enter.

COMPUTER
Memory sliced! Patient entered successfully! Fifteen minutes left.

LAURA
Maybe we should what?

YOUNG DICK
(in a calm voice) Maybe I should be more understanding.

LAURA
What happened? You said you can't do this either.

YOUNG DICK walks up to LAURA and takes her hand.

YOUNG DICK

I can. I think I was drowning soooo deep in my shit that I didn't realize how much of a pain you are in just trying to care for me. I didn't realize that you were complaining not because you didn't want to keep helping me. It was because I couldn't see everything you were sacrificing for me. Because you care about me. Because you love me.

beat.

And, this is not an excuse, but I was subconsciously trying to push you out because deep down… I know that I love you too much to drag you into this shithole with me. Now, I know. You are too selflessly wired to leave. You'd rather spend time with me here than leave to go have fun somewhere else. That's your choice. I don't understand why, but I know I will do the same for you. Because the world is more fun with someone you love. Because you make every party a little more tolerable for me.

beat.

Maybe I still think I don't deserve it. Maybe I still think I don't deserve you. But, maybe I should trust your choice… And, I will.

LAURA stops crying.

YOUNG DICK

So, please stay. I know you want to, and I want you to. Just let me know how to fix this. Tell me how to make this work.

LAURA

(smiles cautiously) I think you should kiss me.

YOUNG DICK smiles with happy tears. He places his hands on LAURA's cheeks. He leans in. They both kiss. The original version of "Campus" by Kale plays again in the background.

COMPUTER

Memory updated! Past altered successfully!
Time's up! Wrapping out of the memory.

The song is fading out.
Lights dim to black. Music stops. Everyone is now off-stage.
silence.
Reception music plays in the background.
Phone rings in the dark.

RECEPTIONIST

Sounds good, sir! We will see you next week. Just come in a bit early to fill out the paperwork.
(laughs) Yeah, you know the procedure already!

beat.

DOCTOR DAVIS
Glad to see you back! When are we going back to this time?

OLD DICK
December 19, 2014… The morning before the party.

DOCTOR DAVIS
Okay! One. Two.. Three… Here we go again!

SCENE 4

Lights are still off. Receptionist talks in the background.

Receptionist

(nervous laugh) No, I don't believe we are getting sued. I am not up to date with the news. Plus everything that you see could technically be a lie you know. But, no matter what, we promise to serve you our best!

Lights come on slowly. There is only SKELETON MARIONETTE. He is carrying a fake guitar. He starts strumming. Melodies (recorded) begins.

SKELETON MARIONETTE

This is my rendition of Campus by Kale.

(sings)

High above the horizon
as light as a dream
I conjured moments that last
right from my mindstream

But, I learned enough times
things come to go
as the wind blows

I am afraid I've decided
Nothing's gonna stop me now
NOTHING'S GONNA STOP ME NOW!

Hide and seek with no point in hiding
Nothing's gonna stop me now
NOTHING'S GONNA STOP ME NOW!

Time is running, falling out
So, nothing's gonna stop me now

Tired of crawling, breaking down
So, nothing's gonna stop me now

DOCTOR DAVIS

Hi! I am Doctor Davis from Phoenix.Inc. I am here to tell you about our most innovative treatment yet. Our latest technological advancements have allowed us to essentially… rewrite time. Yes! You heard that right. Infused with the greatest artificial intelligence, our newest treatment can write you the perfect life you've always dreamed of. Still has doubts? Visit Phoenix.Inc. and announce… you are here to change your mind!

SKELETON MARIONETTE

Start today! And, don't let anything stop you now from changing your life.

SCENE 5

Lights slowly peek in. A warm yellow morning glow. December 19, 2014. The morning before the party. We are back in the dorm room. BEN is cleaning the living room table wearing earbuds. A vase with sunflowers sits on the table. The telescope stands near the window.
A piano rendition of the song "Campus" by Kale plays softly in the background.

BEN

(humming to the song) Nothing's gonna stopppp me nowww…

YOUNG DICK walks in from the back.

YOUNG DICK

You are up early today.

BEN throws a smirk at YOUNG DICK and continues singing.

BEN

Time is running, falling out.
So, nothing's gonna stoppp me nowww…

YOUNG DICK

You doing okay?

The last few notes of piano play in the background. Then, it is silent.

BEN

(takes out one earbud and replies) Not really. But… look at this. *(holds up the vase with sunflowers)* I finally found them again after like an eternity later. It feels like this town wants to PUNISH me for fucking LOVING sunflowers.

YOUNG DICK

You don't have to come to the party.

BEN

Oh come on. Then, who are you going to mingle with? I can't leave my bud like that.

YOUNG DICK

(places hand on BEN's shoulder) I don't have to go. We can just stay in and play some computer games or something.

COMPUTER

Command is not recognized! Please say 'help' to get the list of all possible commands or 'quit' to leave the simulation.

BEN

(smiles) I'll be fine. Party's still like ten hours away anyway. Plus, some hot girls could cheer both of us up.

YOUNG DICK

I want you to be serious. For once.

BEN ignores YOUNG DICK and starts wiping the table.

BEN

(again humming the song) Nothing's gonna stopppp me nowww…

YOUNG DICK

Ben, I am worried. Talk to me.

BEN puts back on the earbud and continues cleaning. The piano plays again. YOUNG DICK yanks it out of his ear. The piano stops.

YOUNG DICK

Hey, talk to me!

BEN

What?!

YOUNG DICK

I need to know if you are okay.

BEN

I am not! I told you…

beat.

But, I should be fine soon.

YOUNG DICK

(frustrated) Okay! I will just leave you alone, then. I will just see you at the party tonight?

BEN

Sure.

BEN snatches back his earbud. He wears it and starts humming the tune again. The piano plays again. YOUNG DICK walks away.

YOUNG DICK

Computer! Rewind ten seconds.

COMPUTER

Memory rewinding!

The tune of the song "Campus" by Kale plays in reverse in the background. YOUNG DICK walks backward. BEN takes his earbud out and places it in YOUNG DICK's hand. Music stops.

BEN

I am not! I told you…

beat.

But, I should be fine soon.

YOUNG DICK

Computer! Enter.

COMPUTER

Memory sliced! Patient entered successfully!

YOUNG DICK

You are lying to me. You are not fine. You are not going to be fine.

BEN

(keeps cleaning) Stop saying those things. You are pissing me off.

YOUNG DICK

Talk to me, Ben. I care about you. Let me know how to make you feel better.

BEN

Walk away.

YOUNG DICK

I am not going to walk away like your previous friends did. Tell me. How do I fix this?

BEN

Fix WHAT?!

BEN slams his fist on the table. The vase with sunflowers falls down.

YOUNG DICK

DON'T do that. We are both just talking here.

BEN

You are interrogating me! *(leans into YOUNG DICK)* I am done here. Have fun alone at the party.

BEN leaves the dorm, slamming the door behind. YOUNG DICK presses his hands on his forehead.

YOUNG DICK

Fuck. Fuck. Fuck. Fuckkkk… Fuck!
Computer! Rewind five minutes!

COMPUTER

Memory rewinding!

Lights go off.
Lights come on. BEN and YOUNG DICK are back in the living room.

BEN

I am not! I told you…
beat.
But, I should be fine soon.

YOUNG DICK

About your parents…

BEN

I don’t want to talk about it, Dick.

YOUNG DICK

It will make you feel better. It will help in the long run. *(reaches out for BEN’s hand)* Trust me.

BEN

Leave it. I am not in the mood.

YOUNG DICK

You won’t ever be in the mood to talk about it. But, it will help you. I know. My parents are dead, too. I wished I had someone to talk to when the wound was fresh.

BEN looks at YOUNG DICK with disappointment. He comes closer to YOUNG DICK and leans in.

BEN

I am not like you. So, stop making everything about yourself and just… leave me alone.

BEN leaves the dorm, slamming the door behind.

YOUNG DICK

Computer! Rewind five minutes!

COMPUTER

Memory rewinding!

Lights go off.

Lights come on. BEN and YOUNG DICK are back in the living room. The piano version of "Campus" by Kale plays.

BEN

I am not! I told you…

beat.

But, I should be fine soon.

The music gets louder and it drowns out the noises. YOUNG DICK is mouthing words. BEN is also mouthing words. They are fighting. BEN slams the door and leaves.

YOUNG DICK *(plays over the speaker)*

Computer! Rewind five minutes!

COMPUTER

Memory rewinding!

Lights go off. The music gets louder.
Lights come on. BEN and YOUNG DICK are back in the living room. They are talking. YOUNG DICK takes BEN's hand. BEN leans in and says words to YOUNG DICK. BEN slams the door and leaves.

YOUNG DICK *(plays over the speaker)*

Computer! Rewind five minutes!

COMPUTER

Memory rewinding!

Lights go off. The music gets louder.
Lights come on. BEN and YOUNG DICK are back in the living room. They are fighting. YOUNG DICK slams his fist on the table. The vase with sunflowers falls. BEN leans in and says words to YOUNG DICK. BEN slams the door and leaves.

YOUNG DICK *(plays over the speaker)*

Computer! Rewind five minutes!

COMPUTER

Memory rewinding! Thirty minutes left.

Lights go off. The music gets louder.
Lights come on. BEN and YOUNG DICK are back in the living room. YOUNG DICK is saying words to BEN. Both holding onto tears and hurt feelings. BEN screams over the loud music.

BEN

For the last time, Dick, I DON'T NEED SAVING!!!

Music fades into the background.

(exhausted) So, Please… stop acting like something's wrong with me.

YOUNG DICK

Ben, just let me in now. I know that you are not fine. Everything has been going wrong in your life. It is okay not to be fine. I am just worried that this could be the event that made you spiral into a shithole. Let me make you feel better, now, and you won't have to deal with this in the future.

BEN

(defeated) Why are you like this? What happened to you?

YOUNG DICK

I am doing this because I care about you. Because I am going to change your life!

BEN

(leans into YOUNG DICK and explodes) WHY ARE YOU SO HELL BENT ON MAKING ME FEEL BETTER? Why don't you just go out and enjoy your life with someone who is not FUCKING depressed?

YOUNG DICK

(pushes BEN out) BECAUSE YOU HAD TO GO AND KILL YOURSELF WHEN I FINALLY WENT OUT ENJOYING MY LIFE!!!

BEN falls backward onto the table. The vase breaks into pieces. Sunflowers lay around him. He seems confused. Tears run down YOUNG DICK's eyes.

BEN

What?

YOUNG DICK

(whispers) Computer! Quit!

All lights go off at once. Pitch black. Some voices in the dark. YOUNG DICK is sobbing.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Hey hey. You are okay. You are okay.

beat.

YOUNG DICK

I fucked up. I kept fucking up. He won't tell me how to fix it.

beat.

DOCTOR DAVIS

It was a hard task. Don't be too harsh on yourself.

beat.

YOUNG DICK

I can't fix anything. I don't know how to fix anything.

beat.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Hey. Hey. You fixed it with LAURA. We both saw it. It was great!

beat.

YOUNG DICK

(defeated) Why won't he tell me how to fix it?

beat.

DOCTOR DAVIS

You got it, Dick. Do you want to try again? You still have about twenty minutes left of this session.

silence.

Lights come on. BEN and YOUNG DICK are back in the living room. No music. Just silence.

BEN

I am not! I told you…

beat.

But, I should be fine soon.

silence.

YOUNG DICK just stares at BEN.

What's up with you? Are YOU okay?

YOUNG DICK

I met a girl, Ben.

BEN

(scoffs) in your dreams?

YOUNG DICK

No, her name is Laura. I took her home after the party. I showed her our telescope *(pointing at the telescope)*. And, the rest came easy.

BEN

Righttttt…

YOUNG DICK

She was very lovely. You would have loved her if you had a chance to get to know her longer. But, we ended up in different cities after graduation, so.

BEN

Don't bring that up. We are not sure yet. We still might be going to the same city. *(puts his hand on YOUNG DICK's shoulder)* Maybe even work at the same company? I've got no other friends now, so I am going to be annoying you a lot *(nervous chuckle)*. Hmmmm. Who knows? Maybe even your girlfriend from your dream can join us.

YOUNG DICK

I should have been a better friend.

BEN

You are a great friend. What do you mean?

YOUNG DICK

After I got closer to LAURA, I kicked you out of the room a lot. I rarely picked up your phone calls. I spent all my holidays with her. You weren't there when I asked her to be my wife. I didn't bother updating you.

BEN

(sarcastically) Wow, that's kinda rude. I would be soooo offended if you didn't dream it all up.

YOUNG DICK

You weren't there at the wedding. *(whispers)* One day, I just got a call from one of our classmates that you…

YOUNG DICK's voice cracks. BEN puts his arm around YOUNG DICK. He pads his back.

BEN

Hey, you good? It's okay. It was just a bad dream. Nothing's real.

YOUNG DICK

I am a bad friend. Before it happened, LAURA and I used to scroll through our old photos together and reminisce. I told her I missed you, but I didn't really feel it. I just said it so that I could feel… human. So that I could feel like I missed someone. So that she didn't think I was heartless.

beat.

I only truly missed you when I was flipping through the yearbook photos and realized I could never see you again. Not in this world. Not in flesh and bones. Then, I couldn't stop hoping for more time.

BEN

Wow. That's kinda fucked up even for a dream. It's okay, bro. Don't youuu worry. We are going to rent an apartment together after college. And, we will have all the time in the world.

COMPUTER

Fifteen minutes left.

YOUNG DICK

I am running out of time. I still don't know how to fix you.

BEN

This again? Why are you trying to fix me?

YOUNG DICK

Because you are my best friend. And also because I am selfish, and I can't live my life like this.

BEN

I don't know man. How do you fix things? I don't fix things. Neither do you.

YOUNG DICK

I just fixed things with LAURA.

BEN

(scoffs) I am happy for you. How did you do that?

YOUNG DICK

(whispers) I just… fixed it. It was easy. But, with you… I just don't know what to do.

BEN is again annoyed by YOUNG DICK's fixation. He leans in closer to YOUNG DICK's face with a death stare.

BEN

If you are so hell-bent, go ahead. Try. But, this is pissing me off again. If you really think I have decided that I am going to *(whispers)* kill myself *(/whispers)*, you better try everything because nothing… and, I mean it, nothing… will stop me then.

YOUNG DICK

(whimpers) I don't know… There must be something I can do.

BEN

I told you. I'm fine. I am glad you fixed it with LAURA in your dreams… however you did it. Good job. You just have to believe me that I am fine and that I am not going to –

Before BEN could finish his sentence, YOUNG DICK pushes his face toward BEN's.

He kisses him.
One second. Two seconds. Three seconds.
BEN pushes him back. He stares at YOUNG DICK in shock.

BEN
(mouths) what the fuck?

YOUNG DICK
(is shaking) Did that… help?

BEN
What the fuck?

YOUNG DICK
Did I fix it?

BEN
What the fuck?!

YOUNG DICK
COMPUTER?

BEN
(frustrated) Whyyyyy did you DO THAT?

YOUNG DICK
Undo that, please.

BEN
UNDO WHAT?!

YOUNG DICK
Forget that!

COMPUTER
Command is not recognized! Please say ‘help’ to get the list of all possible commands or ‘quit’ to leave the simulation.

BEN
Howww… do you want me to FORGET THAT? Are you going INSANE?

YOUNG DICK
(whispers) computer. computer. computer.

BEN pushes YOUNG DICK.

BEN
SAY SOMETHING THAT MAKES SENSE!

YOUNG DICK

(whispers) please let me out.

BEN pushes YOUNG DICK.

BEN

HEY!!!

YOUNG DICK

Pleaseeeee… LET ME OUT!!! Computer -

COMPUTER

Command is not recognized! Please say ‘help’ to get the list of all possible commands or ‘quit’ to leave the simulation.

BEN pushes YOUNG DICK.

BEN

HEY!!! ARE YOU GONNA SAY SOMETHING?

YOUNG DICK

I am sorry. I am sorry.

BEN pushes YOUNG DICK.

COMPUTER

Command is not recognized! Please say ‘help’ to get the list of all possible commands or ‘quit’ to leave the simulation.

BEN

AM I A JOKE TO YOU?!

YOUNG DICK

(closes his eyes and repeats to himself) It’s okay. This is not real. THIS IS NOT REAL!

YOUNG DICK slams both hands on the table. The vase falls.

COMPUTER!!! GET ME OUT OF HERE!

COMPUTER

Command is not recognized! Please say ‘help’ to get the list of all possible commands or ‘quit’ to leave the simulation.

YOUNG DICK

NOTHING’S REAL. YOU ARE NOT REAL. NOT REAL. YOU’RE NOT REAL.

YOUNG DICK walks up to the window, grabs the telescope out of the stand, and smashes it onto the floor. BEN comes to grab YOUNG DICK.

BEN

RICHARD! STOP!!!

YOUNG DICK

COMPUTER!!!!!

COMPUTER

Memory updated! Past altered successfully!
Time’s up! Wrapping out of the memory.

Lights go off. Pitch black.
silence.

SCENE 6

Lights come on. LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE stand in the middle of the stage. The piano rendition of the advertisement song plays. LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE begin singing less cheerfully.

LADY MARIONETTE

We know times are tough.

SKELETON MARIONETTE

We know the world around us is going through an… evolution or two.

LADY MARIONETTE

But, we still want to help.

SKELETON MARIONETTE

So… we wrote a poem for you.

LADY MARIONETTE

(whispers) one. two. three.

LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE

I don't know what's wrong
I just know it hurts
I am once again choked and tied up by the ghosts of my hidden past

Some things stay forever
merged into the shadows on my walls
learned as steps for my late-night dancing
with no chance to unrecall

If I find a way to change
I will leap to redraw my fate
because I love you
If I get the moment to rewrite my ways
because I love you
who's to say I am a con man anyway?

who is to tell me it is wrong
who is to judge my choice
I am once again trying to make peace with the ghosts of my hidden past

Some things stay forever
It's my life. It's my choice.

The audience clapping recording plays in the background. LADY MARIONETTE and SKELETON MARIONETTE take a bow. COMPUTER's and DOCTOR DAVIS' voices play in the background.

COMPUTER

Hi! I am Computer from Phoenix.Inc. I am here to help you make difficult decisions or through unwanted memories by giving you another chance that you've always wanted. Phoenix.Inc is always improving and giving you more ways to connect or reconnect with your past lives. To view the full list of newly available treatments, visit our website www.phoenixinc.changemylife today!

DOCTOR DAVIS

Curious? Visit Phoenix.Inc. and announce… you are here to change your mind!

The audience clapping recording plays again in the background. Curtains come down.

SCENE 7

Curtains open. Bright yellow lights sparkle up the whole stage. A young teenager sits on the floor on stage holding a pen and a book. He writes. BEN's actor does not come on stage but recordings of his voice play in the background.

BEN (in the background)

August 08, 2005
Dear Diary,
Middle school is a nightmare. I don't know how to talk to people nor want to talk to people. Everyone looks so rich and posh. The worst thing is… they look like they already have friends. I don't technically need friends, but it would be nice to get out of this hellhole even for a few minutes. Mom and Dad are constantly fighting. And, I hate people yelling… I can't wait to move out someday and call my own shots.

The young teenager stands up and leaves the stage. Some yellow lights turn to grey.
GUY (can be anyone in high schooler uniform) comes up and picks up the book. BEN and TEEN DICK come up the stage in the same uniform.

GUY

(laughs maniacally) Hahahahaaaha! Look at this dude. He has a diaryyyyy…

BEN

It is… it is a… journal. Can you give it back?

GUY

(waving the book around, laughing) Writing a diary in high school? What? Are you gay?

TEEN DICK

Hey! Give it back to him. Right now.

GUY

Haha. Are you here to defend your little boyfriend? Do you also wanna suck my -

BEN

Dick! You don't have to.

TEEN DICK turns around and stares at BEN looking disappointed. Then, he turns back around. He throws a punch at GUY. TEEN DICK and GUY start fighting on stage. BEN tries to stop them. Suddenly everyone freezes and BEN's voiceover interrupts.

BEN (in the background)

September 15, 2009

Hey Journal,

High school is a nightmare. Dick is pretty cool though… although he insists that I call him Richard. I can't wait to go to college and leave everyone and everything behind!

Some yellow lights turn to grey.
Everyone on stage begins moving. (For crowds or students, shadows can be lit up behind the stage). TEEN DICK and BEN get into graduation gowns. BEN holds a bouquet of sunflowers.

BEN (in the background)

Hey Journal,

I AM GRADUATING!!! Can't wait for college. Dick is coming too!

TEEN DICK leaves the stage. The stage turns into their dorm room. BEN sits on the window pane next to his telescope.

BEN (in the background)

August 06, 2011
Hey Journal,

I moved into my dorm room today. It is actually smaller than I thought it would be. No complaints though. At least I don't have to room with a random. I couldn't bring my Geronimo Stilton book collection. That was a bummer! I sacrificed them to bring my telescope instead. Sometimes, I just feel like the stars know what I really need, you know. Dick was complaining about it taking up space. I told him I could pick up girls with it, and he laughed at me. What a bitch.

Some lights dim.

BEN (in the background)

August 19, 2012
Hey Journal,

Sophomore year is not starting out great. *(continues talking in muffled voice)*

More lights dim.

BEN (in the background)

December 28, 2013
Hey Journal,

Just one more semester left of Junior year. Hope that one goes better than this one. *(continues talking in muffled voice)*

More lights dim.

BEN (in the background)

December 17, 2014
Hey Journal,

I just got the news. My parents passed away in a car accident.

Lights go off. Everything is pitch black. There are some muffled voices in the background. Some voice recording plays.

BEN: I am not! I told you… But, I should be fine soon.

BEN: SENIOR PARTY, HERE WE COME!

YOUNG DICK: I AM GOING TO CHANGE MY LIFE!!!

LAURA: So, you are his roommate, Ben.

YOUNG DICK: Hey bud, can I get the room tonight?

BEN: Oh, Laura. I didn't know you are coming too.

LAURA: Dick is packing my things for me. He said he will miss you.

BEN: We should hang out soon. I can fly over!

YOUNG DICK: Hey! You have reached Richard's number. If you are hearing this message, I am not free right now. So, leave a message after the beep and I will get back to you as soon as possible.

beat.
Lights come on slowly. There is a big staircase with four steps (not a ladder) in the middle of the stage facing sideways to the front audience. BEN is standing on the bottom (first) step. There are four pieces of paper hanging from the ceiling. One for each step of the staircase. BEN grabs the first one in front of him and reads.

BEN

Hey Journal,

I don't like this new city. I don't know how to talk to people nor want to talk to people. Everything just looks so rich and… posh. I don't fit in. And, I don't want to try anymore.

BEN drops the paper. He takes one step up the stairs. He grabs the piece of paper hanging above.

BEN

Hey Journal,

My aunt committed suicide today.

BEN tears up the paper. He takes another step up the stairs. He grabs the piece of paper hanging above.

BEN

Hey Journal,

I just broke up with my boyfriend today. Danny and I just stopped seeing eye to eye and -

OLD DICK (in the background)

Computer! Question.

Everything on stage pauses. OLD DICK and COMPUTER talk in the background.

COMPUTER (in the background)

Memory paused. Please state your question, confusion, or suggestion.

OLD DICK (in the background)

Ben is not gay… At least not that I knew of.

COMPUTER (in the background)

Multiple studies have found that LGBTQ+ young people are more than four times as likely to commit suicide than their peers. This is the most likely situation according to my calculations.

OLD DICK (in the background)

Umm…

COMPUTER (in the background)

Would you like me to modify and generate another scenario?

OLD DICK (in the background)

Yes, please. That would be nice.

COMPUTER (in the background)

Of course! Modifying the situation and regenerating the scene. Enjoy!

BEN continues on stage.

BEN

Hey Journal,

I just broke up with my girlfriend today. Daisy and I just stopped seeing eye to eye and it is hard just letting someone you love go because holding on will just hurt both of us more. I feel… hopeless.

BEN crumbles the piece of paper and throws it away. He takes another step up the stairs. He is at the top now. He takes the last piece of paper hanging above.

BEN

Hey Journal,

I went to a coworker's house for a party. Got pretty drunk and decided to stay the night. *(BEN's voice cracks and his body trembles)* I should not have. All I can remember is that I woke up in the middle of the night with my pants removed and my -

OLD DICK

Computer! What. The. Fuck.

Everything on stage pauses. OLD DICK and COMPUTER talk in the background.

COMPUTER

Command is not recognized! Please say 'help' to get the list of all possible commands or -

OLD DICK

Computer! Question. I just can't believe it. There is no way.

COMPUTER

Research shows that sexual abuse is one of the leading factors relating to suicide. This is the most likely situation according to my calculations. Would you like me to modify and generate another scenario?

OLD DICK

No… I just can't imagine. Ben…

COMPUTER

It is human nature to dismiss the harsh truth sometimes. That is why we have reliable methods like Maths, Science, and Statistics to help people see the truth. This is the most likely situation that caused Ben to commit suicide according to my calculations. If you wish to modify it, I am happy to generate another scenario for you.

OLD DICK

silent.

No… I am okay. Just… continue.

BEN continues. He folds the paper into a paper airplane and let it fly. He observes how high he is. He stands on the edge of the final steps. He begins to hum the tune to a familiar song.

BEN

Nothing's gonna stopppp me nowww…

He lifts his right leg up, takes a step forward, and leans in. No one to hold him. Nothing to stop the fall… at least not before it's too late. All lights go off in unison.

One second. Two seconds. Three seconds.

Lights come back on. OLD DICK and DOCTOR DAVIS are in Doctor's Office.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Now, this one IS A SUCCESS! Unlike that last one. So, now that you have lived through Ben's story and filled in your missing pieces, let's rewrite your painful memories and save these as your main memory. You will FINALLY be able to live knowing that it is not your fault. Just sign this for me right here!

DOCTOR DAVIS passes OLD DICK a piece of paper.

OLD DICK

I don't know. It feels… artificial.

DOCTOR DAVIS

We just helped you fill in some gaps with help from our greatest intelligence.

OLD DICK just stares into space.

You stood up for him. You stayed with him. You did everything you could.

OLD DICK

But, some of these things… they are not real. They cannot be.

beat.

I changed his life.

DOCTOR DAVIS

Dick, let me explain this to you again. Our computer caters to your situation, calculates the most likely outcome, and creates a scenario for you. The one you just saw, even if it is not the whole truth, it should be pretty damn close. And, in most possible scenarios, Dick, I can assure you that you did the best you could. Ben obviously, as we saw, had a rough life. You couldn't have done anything to stop him.

OLD DICK

What if he tried reaching out to me and I was too busy? What if he called me and I just didn't pick up? What if that was the reason? What if the actual reason is because I was ACTUALLY… a bad person?

DOCTOR DAVIS

Let me ask you a question. Do you actually believe that your close friend, Ben, is weak enough to do what he did just because his friend didn't text him back?

OLD DICK shakes his head slowly.

Okay now, try repeating this after me: This is not my fault.

OLD DICK

(reluctantly) This is not my fault.

DOCTOR DAVIS

It's not my fault.

OLD DICK
It’s not my fault.

DOCTOR DAVIS
I tried everything I could.

OLD DICK
I tried… everything I could.

DOCTOR DAVIS
I am going to continue keeping him in my life.

OLD DICK
I am going to continue keeping him in my life.

DOCTOR DAVIS
This is not my fault.

OLD DICK
This is NOT my FAULT.

DOCTOR DAVIS
Yes, it is not your fault. Time flies, and people tend to… die. You are actively making an attempt to remember him and keep him close. I think that is ADMIRABLE.

OLD DICK
I want to remember him. I want to keep him close.

DOCTOR DAVIS
You are a good friend, Dick.

OLD DICK
Thank you! You are the first one to believe that.

DOCTOR DAVIS
Ben and Laura will feel the same, too, now that you are doing this.
OLD DICK finally lets out a small smile.
So, what do you think? Would you like to continue visiting them?
OLD DICK nods.
We offer weekly, monthly, yearly, or lifetime subscriptions. Let me go on our website to show you all the pricings. *(types on the computer)* Here it is. Since you are our repeat customer, we will also give you a 20% discount if you make a purchase today.
OLD DICK stares into the computer.
So, what are you thinking? Ready to change your life?

Lights dim slowly to black.
A calm piano starts playing in the background.

SCENE 8

Lights come on.
There is a dining table in the middle of the room. A vase with sunflowers on the middle of the table. The telescope on the side of the stage.
Three chairs around the table.
YOUNG DICK, SKELETON MARIONETTE, and LADY MARIONETTE sit in the chairs.

They are conversing.
They are laughing.
They are smiling.

EVERYONE
(harmonizing and singing in the background)
Change your mindddd…
beat.
And, change… your… LIFEEEE!!!

The curtains come down.

END OF PLAY